The Last Leaf

The big idea

O. Henry's story is about **Johnsy**, a young artist who falls ill with **pneumonia** and loses the will to live. She believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls. An old, unsuccessful painter, **Behrman**, gives her hope by painting a leaf on the wall on a stormy night, sacrificing his own life. The story shows **hope, friendship and sacrifice**, and ends with a famous **twist**.

Summary

1. **Sue** and **Johnsy** are two young artists sharing a small flat on the top floor of a three-storey building. Johnsy falls seriously ill with **pneumonia**.
2. The **doctor** tells Sue that Johnsy has **one chance in ten**, and that chance depends on her **wanting to live**. Johnsy has made up her mind that she will not get well.
3. Lying in bed, Johnsy counts the leaves falling from an old **ivy creeper** on the brick wall of the house opposite. She says that when the **last leaf** falls, she too will die.
4. Sue tells this to **Behrman**, an old painter living downstairs, who has always talked about painting a **masterpiece** but never has. He is angry at Johnsy's foolish idea.
5. That night there is a heavy **storm**. Next morning, one leaf is still on the creeper, and it remains the next day too.
6. Johnsy feels ashamed of wanting to die. She regains her will to live, asks for food and recovers. The doctor says she is out of danger.
7. Then Sue tells her the truth: **Behrman** had died of **pneumonia** in hospital. He was found soaked and cold on the night of the storm; he had climbed up a

ladder in the rain and **painted the last leaf** on the wall. It was **his masterpiece**.

THE TWIST

The leaf that saved Johnsy's life was not real. Behrman's sacrifice turned a painted leaf into a true masterpiece.

Characters

- **Johnsy**: sensitive, imaginative, depressed by illness; she recovers when she regains hope.
- **Sue**: loyal, caring friend who nurses Johnsy and keeps working to pay for things.
- **Behrman**: gruff, old, a failed artist with a kind heart; he sacrifices his life.
- **The doctor**: realistic; stresses the importance of will power.

Themes

- **Hope and the will to live**.
- **Friendship and selfless love**.
- **Art can save lives**; true achievement lies in sacrifice.

JOHNSY WAS NOT CURED BY MEDICINE ALONE

The doctor clearly says her chance depends on her will. The painted leaf restored her will to live.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did Johnsy think she would die? What did the doctor say? Why was the last leaf Behrman's masterpiece? Describe Sue's friendship. Value points: one chance in ten, ivy leaves, storm, painted leaf, Behrman died of pneumonia.

Quick recap

- Johnsy has pneumonia and links her life to the last ivy leaf.
- Behrman paints a leaf on the wall in a storm.
- Johnsy recovers; Behrman dies; the leaf is his masterpiece.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "The Last Leaf"?
   (a) Oscar Wilde (b) O. Henry (c) Anton Chekhov (d) Katherine Mansfield
2. What illness did Johnsy suffer from?
   (a) Typhoid (b) Malaria (c) Tuberculosis (d) Pneumonia
3. What chance of recovery did the doctor give Johnsy?
   (a) None at all (b) Fifty-fifty (c) One in ten (d) Nine in ten
4. Why did Johnsy count the ivy leaves?
   (a) She believed she would die when the last leaf fell (b) She was painting them (c) She wanted to know when winter would end (d) The doctor asked her to
5. How did Behrman die?
   (a) He fell off a ladder (b) Of old age (c) In an accident in the storm (d) Of pneumonia caught on the stormy night
6. Why is the leaf called Behrman's masterpiece?
   (a) It won a prize (b) It was sold for a large sum (c) It looked so real it saved Johnsy's life (d) It was the largest painting he made
7. Why did Johnsy believe she would die? How did she recover?
8. Write a character sketch of Behrman.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. c 4. a 5. d 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes